

Incident Response Runbook

1. Purpose

This runbook defines how engineers should respond when a production incident is detected, including severity classification, escalation paths, and communication expectations.

2. Severity Levels

2.1 Severity 1 (Critical)

Complete service outage or data loss affecting all customers. Must be acknowledged within 5 minutes. Page the on-call engineer immediately via PagerDuty and notify the Incident Commander on-call rotation.

2.2 Severity 2 (High)

Significant degradation affecting a subset of customers or a core feature. Must be acknowledged within 15 minutes. Page the relevant service owner.

2.3 Severity 3 (Medium)

Minor degradation or a non-critical feature outage. Should be picked up within 2 hours during business hours. Log in the #incidents Slack channel.

2.4 Severity 4 (Low)

Cosmetic issues or edge-case bugs with no meaningful customer impact. Log as a standard ticket, no immediate escalation required.

3. Escalation Path

- Step 1: On-call engineer acknowledges the page and begins triage within the SLA for the assigned severity.
- Step 2: If unresolved within 30 minutes for a Severity 1, escalate to the secondary on-call engineer.
- Step 3: If unresolved within 60 minutes for a Severity 1, the Incident Commander convenes a war room and notifies the Head of Engineering.
- Step 4: Customer-facing communications are handled exclusively by the Customer Success team, coordinated through the Incident Commander.

4. During the Incident

Maintain a live timeline of actions taken in the incident's dedicated Slack channel. Do not deploy unrelated changes to production while a Severity 1 or Severity 2 incident is open.

5. Post-Incident

A blameless postmortem must be completed within 3 business days of any Severity 1 or Severity 2 incident. The postmortem template is available on the internal wiki under 'Incident Postmortems'.